DIWALI 2026

Follow the money.

₹60,000 crore of festive ad spend, read through what I'm learning in Advertising & Sales Promotion at XLRI.

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THE RUNWAY

Diwali came late this year.

6 Nov	8 Nov	10 Nov
Dhanteras	Diwali	Bhai Dooj

About three weeks later than last year.

Brands got a longer runway, and they're using it.

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THE POT

The pot grew 13-17%.



Festive ad spend, India. 2026 is a forecast; the striped end is the top of the range.

Source: Datum Intelligence forecast

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BET 1 · DIGITAL

Two of every three rupees: digital.



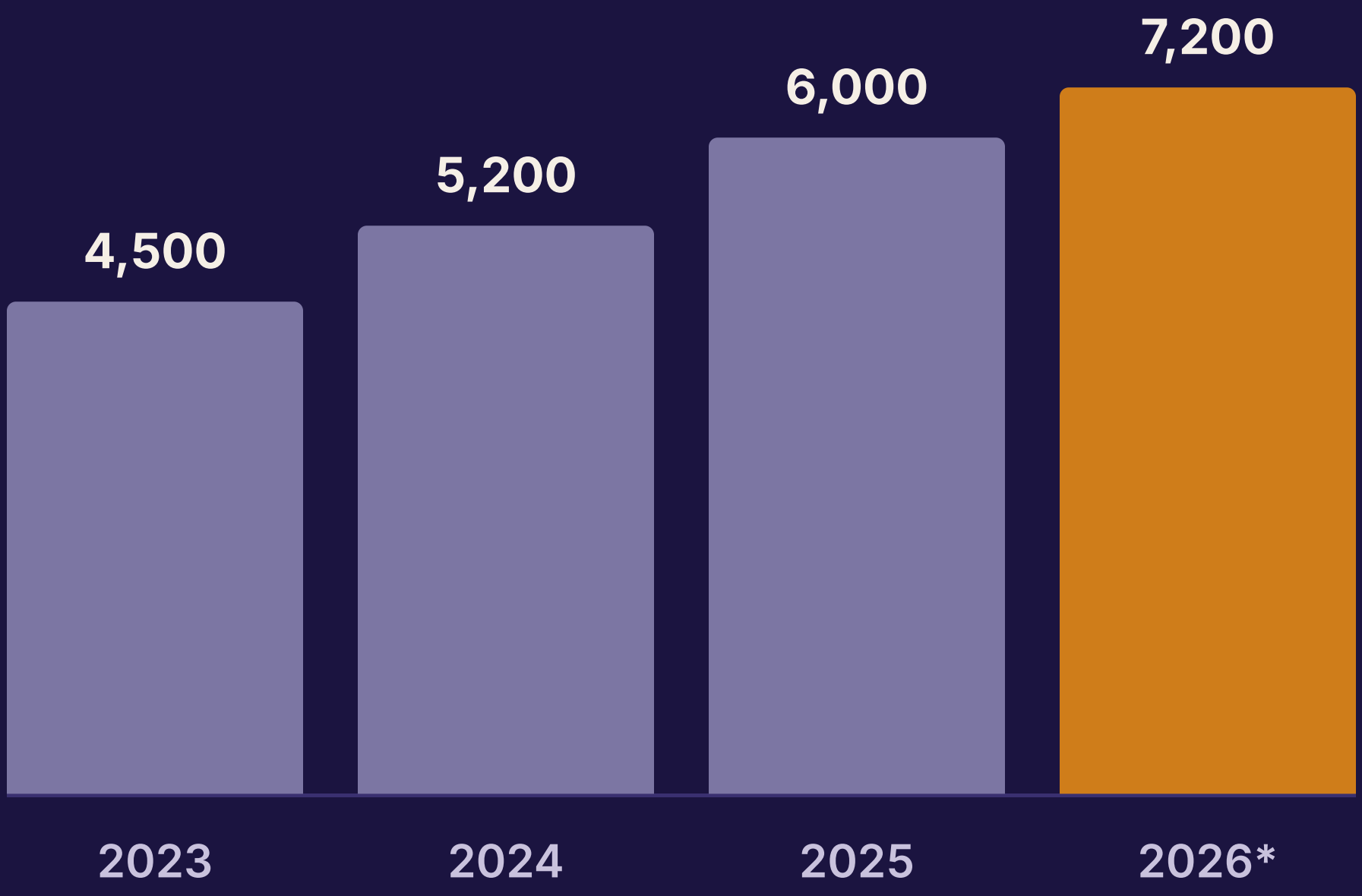
> **Class lens:** digital lets a brand show up at the moment of choice, not just in memory.

Source: Datum Intelligence forecast

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BET 2 · CREATORS

7,200 brands, one feed.



> **Class lens:** creators work because we copy people we trust. Seven thousand brands in one week is noise.

Brands on festive creator campaigns. *Forecast. Qoruz

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BET 3 · QUICK COMMERCE

+50%

₹2,200 crore this festive season

> **Class lens:** purchase facilitation, the fifth communication effect. The ad sits one tap from the cart.

Source: Datum Intelligence forecast

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BET 4 · OUTDOOR

Billboards: sold out.

15-20%

expected outdoor growth, premium sites effectively fully booked

> **Class lens:** media is bought months ahead. The brands that planned early own the best walls.

Source: OOH operators via Storyboard18

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BET 5 · FLEXIBILITY

Budgets on a short leash.

Brands aren't locking full festive budgets months in advance. They want proof first.

> **Class lens:** the same shift agency pay made, from commission to performance.

Source: Bestmediainfo

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MY READ

Diwali doesn't build brands. It cashes them in.

60% brand	40% activation
Builds memory, all year	Festive spend is mostly this

> **Binet & Field:** activation runs on memory the other 11 months built.

Rule of thumb: Binet & Field, IPA

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SAVE THIS

Diwali 2026 in six numbers

1. ₹60-62k crore pot · up 13-17%
2. Digital takes 67.8% · win at the moment of choice
3. 7,200 brands on creators · trust, then noise
4. Quick commerce up 50% · one tap from the cart
5. Outdoor sold out · early planners won
6. Budgets stay flexible · pay for proof

> **The point:** festive spend cashes in a brand. It rarely builds one.

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Which Diwali 2026 ad will you still remember in January?

Tell me in the comments.

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